

Making Schools Human

Spend a day with a ten-year-old boy. You will see him dashing from one activity to the next. Teaching him grammar for forty minutes in an English class is as easy as teaching a hummingbird to play chess. "How was school today, darling?" "Boring!"

Then this kid, this disorganized bundle of nervous energy, will throw down a nourishing dinner of french fries and root beer and disappear upstairs. When you go up to his room two hours later, you find him at his Nintendo helping Mario save a princess. Our hero is engaged, with an industriousness and eagerness that school seldom generates, in learning the rules and strategies of video games, which are much more demanding than any homework assignment. The result is a level of learning far beyond what was attempted in the classroom just a few hours earlier.

I believe computers shouldn't be segregated in a computer lab at schools but should be made available at every student's desk. We have a chance to teach in an effective, lower-cost, and fun way by making the computer in the classroom as much a part of student life as the Sega or Nintendo machine is at home. Computers can do what teachers often cannot: instruct at the individual pupil's level of knowledge, repeat troublesome areas, and keep the student interested through imaginative presentations.

As more educators convert to that point of view, investment opportunities arise. Companies I've owned, such